

How to Apply for Claude for Open Source

A practical, legitimate step-by-step guide to applying for Anthropic's Claude for Open Source program and activating access only after official approval.

Important

This is an unofficial guide. Approval is not guaranteed. Do not fake approval emails, bypass eligibility checks, or share passwords. Apply only through the official Claude/Anthropic page.

Program	Claude for Open Source
Benefit	6 months of Claude Max 20x for approved open-source maintainers/contributors
Primary eligibility	Primary maintainer/core team member of a public repo with 5,000+ GitHub stars OR 1M+ monthly NPM downloads, with recent activity
Fallback route	If you maintain something the ecosystem quietly depends on, apply and explain the impact
Review	Rolling review, up to 10,000 contributors according to the official program page

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1. What the program gives you

Claude for Open Source is an application-based program from Anthropic for open-source maintainers and contributors. The official program page says approved applicants receive a link to activate Claude Max on their account for the subscription period. The page describes the benefit as 6 months of free Claude Max 20x. [1]

Claude Max 20x is the higher-capacity Max tier. Claude's Max plan documentation describes Max 20x as offering substantially more usage than Pro, with access to Claude Code and priority access to newer features/models. Public Max pricing lists Max 20x at \$200/month as of the cited source. [2][3]

Reality check

This is not a universal free subscription. You apply, Anthropic reviews, and only approved applicants receive an activation link. Nobody should claim approval until they have received an official message from Claude/Anthropic.

2. Eligibility checklist

You are a primary maintainer or core team member of a public repository.

1 Examples: owner, maintainer, core committer, release manager, or someone with meaningful review/merge responsibility.

Your public repo has 5,000+ GitHub stars OR 1M+ monthly NPM downloads.

2 Use your strongest project. If you have multiple projects, choose the one with the clearest public impact.

You have recent activity in the last 3 months.

3 Examples: commits, releases, pull request reviews, issue triage, security fixes, documentation updates.

If you do not hit the public metrics, you can still apply under the exception route.

4 Explain why your project is a quiet dependency, useful internal tool, important learning resource, or developer product

Best approach if you do not fully qualify

Be honest. Do not inflate stars, downloads, users, or maintainer status. Instead, explain the practical value of your project, who benefits, and exactly how Claude Max would improve documentation, testing, debugging, code review, release quality, and maintenance.

3. Documents and proof to prepare before applying

- Official GitHub repository link or NPM package link.
- Your role in the project: maintainer, core contributor, release owner, documentation maintainer, triager, etc.
- Public signals: GitHub stars, forks, dependents, NPM monthly downloads, active issues/PRs, recent releases.
- Recent activity proof from the last 3 months: commits, release notes, PR reviews, merged PRs, issue triage, security patches.
- Short impact summary: who uses it, what problem it solves, and why it matters to the developer ecosystem.
- Usage plan: how Claude Max will help you maintain the project responsibly.

4. Step-by-step application process

Open the official page

- 1 Go to: <https://claude.com/contact-sales/claude-for-oss>

Read the program details

- 2 Confirm eligibility, subscription details, terms, and any deadline or cap shown on the official page.

Select your strongest project

- 3 Use the project where your role, recent activity, and ecosystem impact are easiest to verify.

Fill in your details truthfully

- 4 Use your real name, email, repository/package links, role, and recent contribution details.

Write the impact statement

- 5 Explain the project impact and how Claude Max will improve maintenance, quality, docs, reviews, and support.

Submit the form

- 6 Applications are reviewed on a rolling basis according to the official page. Save a copy of what you submitted.

Wait for official review

- 7 Do not assume approval until you receive a genuine Claude/Anthropic confirmation.

Activate from the official link only

- 8 If approved, use only the official activation link and verify the domain before logging in.

5. What to write in the application

A strong application is specific, verifiable, and impact-focused. Avoid writing only: "I want Claude for free." Instead, connect Claude Max to open-source maintenance outcomes.

Weak	Better
I need Claude Max for coding.	Claude Max would help me review pull requests, write tests, improve documentation, triage issues, and maintain release quality for my open-source project.
My repo is useful.	The project helps developers solve [specific problem]. It is actively maintained through recent commits/releases/PR reviews, and users depend on it for [specific workflow].
I do not meet stars/downloads.	Although the project does not meet the headline metrics yet, it has practical ecosystem value because [specific users/dependents/use cases].

Copy-ready application pitch

Template

I'm applying under the category for applicants who may not fully meet the public star or download threshold. While my project may not yet have large public visibility, I actively build and maintain developer-focused work that solves practical engineering problems and supports other developers.

Access to Claude Max would help me improve documentation, code review, testing, debugging, issue resolution, and overall project quality. I would use it responsibly to make my open-source contributions more consistent, maintainable, and valuable to the developer ecosystem.

6. Stronger pitch for the “do not fully fit” route

Polished version

Although my project does not yet meet the 5,000+ stars or 1M monthly downloads threshold, I believe it still aligns with the spirit of the Claude for Open Source program. I actively build and maintain software that supports developers through practical tools, learning resources, reusable code, and engineering workflows.

Access to Claude Max would directly help me improve code quality, documentation, testing, issue resolution, and long-term maintainability. I would use it to review pull requests, generate clearer documentation, identify edge cases, improve test coverage, and respond to issues more efficiently. This would allow me to contribute more effectively and responsibly to the open-source community.

Customize it with real proof

- Project name and link: “I maintain [project] at [URL].”
- Role proof: “I am responsible for releases, reviews, and issue triage.”
- Impact proof: “It is used by [developers/students/teams] to solve [problem].”
- Recent activity: “In the last 3 months I shipped [release/fix/docs/tests].”
- Claude usage plan: “I will use Claude Max for PR review, docs, tests, debugging, refactoring, and maintenance.”

7. How to verify an official approval email

Only trust a confirmation that comes through an official Claude/Anthropic channel. Anthropic help guidance says official marketing emails are sent from domains ending in anthropic.com or claude.com. [4]

Check	What to look for
Sender domain	The visible sender and return path should be from an official Claude/Anthropic domain, such as anthropic.com or claude.com. Be cautious with lookalikes.
Link domain	Hover before clicking. Activation should go to official domains such as claude.ai, claude.com, or anthropic.com.
No password request	No official email should ask you to send your password, OTP, recovery code, or payment information by email.
Account match	The activation should connect to the same Claude account/email that applied or the email specified by the official instructions.

Security warning

Do not create or forward fake approval emails. Do not click suspicious activation links. If the email looks strange, open Claude directly in your browser and check your account or contact official support.

8. Activation after approval

- Open the official approval email and verify the sender/domain first.
- Click the official activation link only if the link domain is legitimate.
- Log in to your Claude account using the official Claude site.
- Follow the activation instructions shown by Claude/Anthropic.

- Confirm your plan status inside account settings, not only from the email text.
- Check whether any payment or renewal terms apply after the 6-month period.
- Save the terms/confirmation for your records.

9. Practical usage plan after activation

If approved, use the subscription in a way that supports open-source maintenance. A clear usage plan also strengthens your application.

Area	How Claude Max can help
Code review	Review PRs, spot risky changes, suggest edge cases, summarize diffs, and generate reviewer checklists.
Testing	Create unit/integration test ideas, improve coverage, find missing scenarios, and generate regression test plans.
Documentation	Improve README, API docs, contribution guidelines, changelogs, migration notes, and examples.
Debugging	Investigate bug reports, reason through stack traces, reproduce issues, and propose root-cause analysis.
Refactoring	Plan safe refactors, identify design trade-offs, and document migration steps for users.
Community support	Draft helpful issue replies, triage templates, release announcements, and maintainer notes.

10. Common mistakes to avoid

- Do not say you are approved unless you have official confirmation.
- Do not fake GitHub stars, NPM download counts, role, or contribution history.
- Do not use someone else's project link unless you are genuinely a maintainer/core contributor.
- Do not paste passwords, private tokens, API keys, or confidential company code into the application.
- Do not trust activation links from unofficial domains or forwarded screenshots.
- Do not assume the subscription will renew for free after 6 months.

11. Quick final checklist

- ☐ I have the official application link.
- ☐ I checked the latest eligibility and terms on Claude/Anthropic pages.
- ☐ I selected my strongest public project.
- ☐ I have proof of maintainer/core contributor role.
- ☐ I have recent activity proof from the last 3 months.
- ☐ I wrote a specific impact statement.
- ☐ I explained exactly how Claude Max will improve maintenance quality.
- ☐ I will wait for official approval before activation.

References

[1] Claude for Open Source official program page, claude.com/contact-sales/claude-for-oss. The page states the program offers 6 months of free Claude Max 20x, lists maintainer eligibility, invites "don't quite fit" applicants to explain ecosystem dependency, and says approved applicants receive an activation link.

[2] Claude Help Center: "What is the Max plan?" The help article describes Max 5x/20x benefits, higher usage capacity, Claude Code access, and monthly pricing.

[3] Claude pricing page for Max, claude.com/pricing/max. The page describes Max 20x as offering up to 20x more usage per session than Pro and lists public pricing as of the cited crawl.

[4] Claude Help Center: "Official Anthropic marketing email addresses." The article says official marketing emails are sent from domains ending in anthropic.com or claude.com.

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